RAJASTHAN

GEHLOT IN CHOPPY WATERS

By Rohit Parihar



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Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot turned 71 this May, but the woes of his crisis-ridden government left no space for any sense of elation or fulfilment. In fact, even as celebrations were happening on May 3, news came that riots had broken out in Jodhpur, his hometown. Then came allegations of rape and sexual exploitation of a news anchor by the son of his closest aide in the cabinet. Meanwhile, the Enforcement Directorate is turning the screws in the probe into the teacher recruitment exam paper leak case. All this has become a dampener ahead of the Congress party national *chintan shivir* (brainstorming session) scheduled to be held in Udaipur from May 13-15.

With the assembly election due in December 2023, politics is hotting up in Rajasthan. The opposition BJP is already targeting Gehlot with the 'Muslim appeasement' card after the riots. On May 10, at a BJP event in Suratgarh with party chief J.P Nadda in attendance, ex-chief minister Vasundhara Raje was caustic in her comments: "The Gehlot government has made Rajasthan number one in riots, having already done so in corruption, unemployment and crimes against women." The last perhaps had to do with the alleged rape case against Rohit Joshi, the married son of PHED (public health engineering department) minister Mahesh Joshi. Delhi Police has registered a case in this regard and has recorded the statement of the 23-year-old complainant, a news anchor who was earlier with a Jaipur-based TV channel. The zero FIR lists a series of alleged incidents, including the victim being forcibly taken from Delhi by a police team from Jaipur in February and made to sign a statement, incidents of 'rape' with the promise of marriage, the making of compromising videos, even scenes of gun shots being fired. If the victim persists with her charges and Delhi Police follows up on the investigation, it will be difficult for Gehlot to let Joshi continue as his minister and defend the role of the Jaipur police in the alleged cover-up.

The state police and Gehlot's bureaucracy already have their backs to the wall over the series of communal clashes in the state, the latest on May 9 when Muslim revellers clashed with members of the Sikh community in Bharatpur (15 people were arrested).


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Gehlot was still smarting under the bad publicity from the riots in Karauli last month when the violence broke out in Jodhpur on May 3. The expectation had been that the administration would be on extra alert, especially with another ongoing controversy over the demolition of part of a 300-year-old temple in Rajgarh, Alwar, last month. Although the government accuses the local BJP-run municipality in Alwar for giving the go-ahead, the saffron party has succeeded in creating an alternative narrative—the 'bulldozing' of Hindu faith as retaliation for the 'action against Muslim rioters in BJP-ruled states'.